

DAP sports a slick interface and a host of features

search results. While selecting a user to download a file from, remember a few things: try to download from a set of users rather than a single user. This means segmentation, and is similar to the mirror-download technique. Also, you can view the connection type of the user and the ping time. Use a faster connection type (for example, an 128 K ISDN is faster than a 56 K), with a lower ping for the fastest downloads. Avoid entering user queues while downloading, as these typically take a long time. Along with this, always check the file size—find the file size on a Web site, or compare with other search results. While searching for files on a P2P network, look for file information. This is necessary because P2P networks may have files that are illegal or corrupted.

WinMX 3.31 (www.winmx.com) is a powerful software that has a large number of established users. The program has a customisable interface that displays the core features of the program up front. The program does not place a restriction on the file type. This makes it ideal for downloading freeware applications. It also supports OpenNap networks that

give you a much larger database to search from. The program has multi-point downloading that allows you to resume a particular download from a different user—this does not leave you dependant on a single user.

KaZaA (www.kazaa.com) is the most popular P2P application available. It sports a clean interface, and you'll get acclimatised pretty quickly. The program does a good job of keeping the process simple, while using all its automated features to give you a comfortable download. It also sports a simplistic media player that can be used while previewing media files. The interface is fully skinnable. KaZaA has



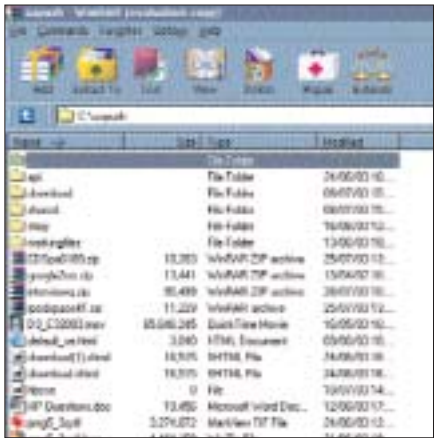
- There are many factors that you must consider while downloading a file:
- Download files only from reputed Web sites
 - Search for a Web site with multiple mirrors for segmented downloading
 - Always download from a Web site that supports resuming of downloads
 - Categorise your downloads either before starting downloads, or after the download is done. This can be done using in-built download managers or file organisers
 - Scan a file for viruses after the download is completed. Do this by setting the anti-virus option in the download manager, or by manually scanning for viruses. Be sure to update your virus definitions periodically

a problem, though, with spyware add-ons during installation.

If you wish to download songs the legal way, check out Altnet for KaZaA. In every search result, Altnet inserts listings for the song you are looking for. These files are either promotional content, or require you to pay. Such systems also help bridge the gap between the music industry and file-sharing networks.

Open thy files

After you download a file, what do you do with it? If it's an archive, you'll need an extraction software. Compression formats usually need specific programs, but if you do not want to overload your PC with compression software, try using these popular software programs that can decompress almost any format.



WinRAR has a slew of features not found in many compression programs

Ping-Pong!

To find out how far the server is from your location, try to ping the site. To do this, go to the Command Prompt and type 'ping', followed by the Web site address. So, to ping Google, enter the command 'ping www.google.com.' You will see a test result similar to this:

```
C:\>ping google.com
Pinging google.com [216.239.53.100] with 32 bytes of data:
Reply from 216.239.53.100: bytes=32 time=478ms TTL=53
Reply from 216.239.53.100: bytes=32 time=474ms TTL=53
Reply from 216.239.53.100: bytes=32 time=625ms TTL=53
Reply from 216.239.53.100: bytes=32 time=703ms TTL=53
Ping statistics for 216.239.53.100:
```

```
Packets: Sent = 4, Received = 4, Lost = 0 (0% loss),
Approximate round trip times in milli-seconds:
Minimum = 474ms, Maximum = 703ms, Average = 570ms
```

Pay attention to the number stated as 'Average'. According to the result shown above, it will take an average of 570 milliseconds for a packet of 32 bytes to reach Google.com, and a response to be sent. Hence, if a Web site has servers in different locations, select to download from the one that provides a response in the least time.